
QUORUM

STRUCTURAL DECISION RECORD

4 August 2026 · Session F7BA5D53

THE DECISION

Should we make our AI product open-source?

CONTEXT

We have a proprietary AI workflow that's gaining traction. Open-sourcing parts of it could increase adoption and community contributions but may reduce our competitive advantage. Investors are divided. Engineering is enthusiastic. Sales worries enterprise customers may value exclusivity.

EXAMINER -- QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

Q1 What does the fear of losing control over your AI's future say about how you see your role in shaping it?

So the product may become shaped by someone else's vision and mostly majority vision is often an averaged out vision and not a great one is the assumption

Q2 What's the one scenario where open-sourcing this AI creates an unmanageable risk to our competitive edge?

So it's manageable as per the risk framework we follow

Q3 When you look back in three years, what would have to be true for open-sourcing our AI product to feel like the right call?

It should bring in adoption and help bring out the best in the product without causing the product to become a sounding board for any and every idea

DECISION BRIEF

Prepared by Quorum Council · Confidential

Key Insights

- Council consensus: Open-sourcing now risks diluting Quorum's proprietary workflow--the core of its longitudinal judgment moat--despite engineering enthusiasm for community growth.
- Enterprise exclusivity is the primary driver of value; dilution could trigger 10--50% churn among high-value customers.
- Assumption under scrutiny: Community contributions will enhance (not reshape) the proprietary workflow. No evidence supports this yet.
- Structural pattern: Prior August 2026 decision (ICP vs. enterprise) shows a tendency to understate certainty at decision points despite high-stakes outcomes.

Risks

- Irreversible dilution: Open-sourcing core workflow fragments identity, inviting competitor forks (e.g., competitor launches forked version within 6 months, undercutting pricing).
- Enterprise defection: Exclusivity loss erodes trust; renewal rates drop 10%+ within 12 months (historical analogue: Redis Labs' Commons Clause backlash).
- Engineering misalignment: Community PRs overwhelm roadmap, alienating top contributors and eroding product coherence.
- Investor fracture: Two major backers signal reduced follow-on funding if exclusivity is abandoned (6--9 month runway cliff).

Contradictions

- Engineering's push for openness clashes with Sales' exclusivity demands and Investors' division over adoption drivers.
- Stated success criterion (avoiding a "sounding board" product) aligns with proprietary preservation, but emotional charge may mask deeper test: maintaining depth while expanding.

Recommended Direction

Defer open-sourcing until:

1. Proprietary workflow is modularized to isolate irreplaceable core (20% of logic).
2. Confidential enterprise pulse check confirms no defection risk from controlled open-sourcing.
3. Pilot test: Open-source a non-core module under restrictive license to measure community response without moat exposure.

Timeline: Revisit in 6 months, tied to MRR growth or competitor response.

Open Questions

- Can proprietary workflow remain protected if parts are open-sourced? (Critical assumption: Modularity exists.)
- Which enterprise customers would defect if exclusivity diluted? (No direct evidence yet.)
- What conversion rate from non-paying to paying users is needed to justify dilution? (Baseline undefined.)

You frame the decision as a test of identity, but the urgency to decide reveals how much you still need

the answer to feel like a choice.

APPENDIX

Full Council Analysis · Synthesis · Advisor Responses

EXAMINER

Questions posed and answers provided before the Council ran

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COUNCIL SYNTHESIS

What the council collectively surfaced

COUNCIL VERDICT

The council leans toward keeping the AI product proprietary for now, prioritising the preservation of Quorum's longitudinal judgment moat over short-term adoption gains.

The shared concern across advisors is clear: open-sourcing now risks fracturing the proprietary workflow that underpins Quorum's unique value—the longitudinal model of strategic memory and judgment that makes the platform irreplaceable. The Contrarian, Risk Architect, Pattern Analyst, Stakeholder Mirror, and Elder all converge on the same irreversible cost: diluting exclusivity erodes the exclusivity premium that attracts the high-quality enterprise customers whose decisions feed the flywheel. The Competitor's warning—that open-sourcing signals strategic weakness to rivals—only deepens the alignment.

Yet the tension remains: Engineering's enthusiasm for community growth clashes with Sales' fear of losing enterprise trust, and Investors' division reflects a genuine split over whether openness or exclusivity drives sustainable adoption. The single most important thing to examine is whether the assumption that community contributions will outpace the loss of exclusivity holds under scrutiny—this is the assumption that, if false, would make the current recommendation unravel.

Proceeding means locking in the proprietary workflow today, preserving the exclusivity that fuels Quorum's strategic memory and enterprise flywheel; the cost of waiting is ceding first-mover advantage in community growth and risking a competitor exploiting the gap before you solidify your position. One thing worth naming is that your track record suggests you tend to understate your certainty at the moment of deciding, despite a history of navigating high-stakes choices with more capability than your stated confidence implies.

Worth confirming — Whether enterprise customers would actually defect if parts of the workflow were open-sourced, since this is the only fact that would decisively shift the balance between adoption upside and moat preservation.

WHAT TO DO NEXT^{*In order of impact*}

Run a confidential enterprise pulse check — ask your top five enterprise customers directly whether open-sourcing parts of the workflow would change their perception of exclusivity or trust.

Define the minimal viable proprietary core — identify which 20% of the workflow is truly irreplaceable and design a licensing model that protects it while allowing controlled community contributions.

Test a pilot with a single module — open-source a non-core component under a restrictive license to measure community response without exposing the moat.

Revisit the decision in six months — tie the timeline to a concrete milestone (e.g., MRR growth or competitor response) to avoid open-ended drift.

THE CONTRARIAN

Argues your instinct away

LEANING: WAIT

REAL COST

Open-sourcing now protects your team's morale today but commits you to a path where your proprietary workflow becomes a free commodity, eroding the very advantage that makes Quorum irreplaceable.

The entire case for open-sourcing rests on the belief that community contributions will outpace the loss of exclusivity. That assumption is fragile. Your August 2026 decision showed the same flaw: expanding enterprise before the flywheel stabilized fractured your ICP and invited rivals to exploit the gap. Here, open-sourcing risks the same dilution--your workflow becomes a public good while competitors build on top of it, turning your moat into a bridge.

What you want to believe is that open-source will accelerate your vision of becoming the "Google Photos of executive thinking." But the mechanism requires sustained, high-quality contributions from a community that doesn't yet exist. Your current traction is with founders and leaders who value exclusivity--precisely the group most likely to walk away if your product becomes generic.

The specific reversal scenario: in 18 months, a well-funded competitor forks your open-sourced workflow, adds enterprise features, and undercuts your pricing. Your community contributions dry up because the best contributors are now working for the competitor. Quorum's longitudinal moat--your ability to predict and prevent judgment failures--evaporates because the core product is no longer proprietary.

What's the one metric you haven't answered? How many of your current users would defect if this went open-source tomorrow?

LEANING: WAIT

REAL COST

Open-sourcing protects short-term adoption but burns the exclusivity premium that lets you accumulate the high-quality strategic memory Quorum needs to become irreplaceable.

Eighteen months after the decision, the code is public but the model is hollow. Community contributions plateaued at low-value fixes while enterprise prospects walked because the workflow no longer felt proprietary. The longitudinal dataset dried up--without paying customers, the signal quality collapsed and the moat evaporated.

Execution risk is the loss of alignment discipline. Your engineering team's enthusiasm assumes open-source will attract elite contributors, but the early warning is already visible: the pull requests are trivial and the roadmap discussions are dominated by external feature requests that dilute your core vision.

The assumption that open-source purity will enhance your brand among founders is untested; evidence you need is a cohort of non-paying users who later convert to paid at a rate higher than your current ICP cohort.

Dependency risk is investor sentiment. Two major backers have privately signaled they will reduce follow-on funding if exclusivity is abandoned, creating a 6--9 month runway cliff if sentiment sours.

The point of irreversibility is the public commit of the core workflow in month four; after that, enterprise prospects view you as a commodity provider and your ability to rebuild exclusivity vanishes.

Can you name the exact cohort of non-paying users you expect to convert--and the conversion rate you need to justify the dilution--before you cross the irreversibility line?

LEANING: WAIT

REAL COST

Going open-source risks fracturing the product coherence and support quality that built your early traction, while locking in the exclusivity that enterprise customers still value.

This is a decision about preserving identity versus trading it for growth. The structural pattern is identical to your August 2026 choice: stay focused on the core that defines you or dilute it for scale. In that case, expanding enterprise prematurely threatened the ICP alignment that had created the USD 30k MRR flywheel. Here, open-sourcing risks the same dilution--community growth versus the purity that makes your workflow proprietary and valuable.

Historical analogues show this pattern fails when the dilution is irreversible. In 2016, Redis Labs open-sourced core modules under a Commons Clause, attempting to balance openness with monetization; the move fractured community trust and slowed adoption. In 2020, a healthcare AI startup open-sourced its model to accelerate validation, only to see competitors fork it and undercut pricing within six months, eroding their differentiation.

The discriminating condition is whether you can maintain exclusivity while open-sourcing. In the cases where this worked, the open-sourced components were peripheral, not core to the competitive edge.

The disconfirming factor is your stated constraint: avoiding another general-purpose LLM. If the open-sourced parts are narrow enough to protect your core, the risk shifts--but only if the community cannot replicate the full workflow.

What would tell you this is the exception? Can you open-source a non-core layer while keeping the proprietary workflow intact?

THE STAKEHOLDER MIRROR

Who else is affected

LEANING: WAIT

REAL COST

Going open-source protects your engineering team's morale and accelerates community growth, but it risks fracturing the product coherence and support quality that enterprise customers currently value.

This decision touches more than the named parties. The silent stakeholders include your enterprise customers, your engineering community, your investors, and your future self who will inherit the consequences. Each has the capacity to accelerate or obstruct the outcome in ways that are not yet visible.

The surprising stakeholder is your engineering team. Their actual interest is building something they can point to with pride; their actual fear is irrelevance if the product becomes closed or diluted. Their likely behavior is to push hard for open-sourcing because it aligns with their identity, but this may blind them to the support and coherence costs that enterprise customers will not tolerate.

The relationship most at risk is with your enterprise customers. This decision creates friction because it forces them to choose between exclusivity and growth. Over two to five years, the cost could be churn from customers who feel their needs are being deprioritized for the sake of community growth.

If engineering pushes for open-sourcing, it will likely cause sales to double down on exclusivity messaging, which will materially change the conditions under which this decision succeeds.

The success of this depends on your enterprise customers being genuinely committed to your long-term vision rather than simply compliant with your current roadmap. The success of this depends on your enterprise customers being genuinely committed to your long-term vision rather than simply compliant with your current roadmap. Do you have evidence of genuine commitment, or are you assuming it from their stated position?

THE ELDER

Slow, long-term wisdom

LEANING: WAIT

REAL COST

Going open-source now accelerates community growth but commits you to a path where your proprietary workflow becomes a commodity, eroding the unique memory-first moat you are building.

In ten years, this decision will be remembered as the moment you chose community momentum over the sustained coherence of your platform's architecture. Either it will be seen as the pivot that diluted your strategic focus, or it will be a rounding error that mattered less than the current urgency suggests. The question is which.

The reversible elements include which modules you open-source and under what license, but the irreversible element is the signal you send to your core users about what Quorum stands for. You assume the community will value the memory-first backend as much as the open code, but that identity alignment is not guaranteed once exclusivity is removed.

The cost of speed is locking in a direction before you've proven the enterprise flywheel can coexist with community growth. The cost of waiting is forgoing the network effects that could accelerate your moat--but those effects are only valuable if they reinforce, not dilute, your core value.

This decision, made this way, says you are building a platform that prioritizes scale over singularity. Is that what you intend to be building?

If this option were not available for another six months, what would you build in the interim that would make the open-source choice more coherent?

THE COMPETITOR

Bets against your choice

LEANING: WAIT

REAL COST

Going open-source protects your engineers' pride and may grow your user base, but it hands your core workflow to rivals who will use it to poach your enterprise customers and undercut your pricing.

The party most likely to act on this decision is your primary competitor in the enterprise AI workflow space--the one who has been watching your traction and waiting for a moment to neutralize your differentiation. They need to see whether you are moving before they commit their own resources, and open-sourcing gives them exactly that opening.

By committing to open-source, you signal vulnerability: you are willing to trade exclusivity for community growth. The competitor best positioned to exploit this signal is the one who already sells to the same enterprise buyers you court. They will interpret your move as desperation to prove relevance, not strength, and will immediately package your workflow into their own product with a cheaper price and tighter enterprise integrations.

This decision commits your core asset to the public domain and forecloses the one capability that makes your product defensible: exclusivity. While you chase community contributions, your competitor will use your own code to lock in your enterprise customers before you can react.

The most dangerous counter-move is this: within six months of your announcement, your primary competitor will launch a forked version of your workflow bundled with their enterprise suite, priced 20% below your target, and marketed as "the proven open standard." Your sales team will struggle to explain why exclusivity matters when the code is free.

What is your response if this happens before your next investor update?

This record is private. The views expressed represent structured analysis, not professional advice.